and Kunbi communities were recognised as part of Goa's tribal matrix and added to the ST list. The numbers may swell further, if the pastoralist Gouly Dhangar community's demand for tribal status is also granted.

Currently, they form 6.92 per cent of North Goa's population (56,606 out of 818,008) and as much as 14.47 per cent of South Goa (92,669/640,537). They have substantial numbers in the Priol, Nuvem, Quepem, Sangeum and Velim assembly constituencies.

The tribal question is not an aside in Goa politics. Though the STs have 12.5 per cent quotas in jobs and education, political reservations had hitherto eluded them. This has long been an emotive issue, having spawned a two-decade history of protests.

A significant flashpoint came in 2011, when two tribal youth died in violence during a protest. That turned out to be a turning point for Goa, since the tribal backlash in the subsequent 2012 election is what sealed the fate of the then Congress government, bringing the BJP back to power. It has ruled Goa since, but had evaded the tribal question for a dozen-odd years. Tribal unrest peaked again last year, and is said to have singed the BJP in the South Goa Lok Sabha seat, where its candidate Pallavi Dempo was trounced by Captain Viriato Fernandes (retd) of the Congress.

Govind Shirodkar of 'Mission Political Reservation for Scheduled Tribes of Goa'—among the groups that spearheaded the protests—says the quota must come into force in the 2027 assembly election. "They cannot take us for granted anymore," he adds.

Political quotas will come, but the establishment is likely to chafe at the group's other demands: implementation of the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, and declaration of Scheduled Areas.

Takeaways

- **Parliament passes a bill to grant quotas in the Goa assembly for tribals**
- **10.23 per cent of Goa's population, the tribal vote sways at least five seats**
- **Political quotas will come, but the government is likely to chafe at other demands of tribal groups**

THE RIGHT TO SPACE

Besides the Gauda, Kunbi and Velip continuum—numerically (and politically) more significant—it's these statutory protections that will be relevant to smaller indigenous groups like the Dubla, Naikda, Varli and Dhodia, besides the Siddis of African descent. Capt. Fernandes, who raised the quota issue in Parliament, bats for justice and rights to the tribals. "They are the 'Niz Goenkars', the original inhabitants of Goa," he says. "Their contribution to Goa has been immense."

Damodar Naik, Goa BJP president, credits his party's governments at the Centre and state for enshrining this formally. "Political reservations will help transform the lives of Goa's tribal communities," he says, citing how the 12 per cent quota was given during the tenure of Manohar Parrikar as Goa CM. Of the state's four tribal MLAs, three (including Speaker Ramesh Tawadkar) are from the BJP and one independent also backs the regime. ■



By **Jumana Shah**

THE CONGRESS IN Gujarat was wont to send wedding horses to compete in the races, and vice versa, Rahul Gandhi famously said in April 2025. The unkind wag may have quipped in response that it hasn't owned race horses for a while, and those that it did acquire tended to bolt towards saffron stables. That wouldn't have been one bit untrue, and in fact was one of the Grand Old Party's chief headaches. Anyway, Rahul's metaphorical note set the tone for a process of reconstruction—its nth attempt in a state where it has not seen power since the 20th century.

Three months later, the burst of perestroika saw the state party reins going back to Amit Chavda, 49, an OBC leader and five-term MLA who performed the same role with some